



bearing the brunt.

"The first reason for a lot of events missing participants is that the meet is being held during the off-season for the athletes," KIUG athletics competition manager Rakesh Save explained.

"Even the athletes who are in camp will not be allowed to participate now because this is an off-season for them. They have to get trained for the next season," he added. Numerous events witnessed a lack of participants, to the extent that the men's 400m hurdles final and the women's 400m final were run by Swarnim Gujarat Sports University's Ruchit Mori and Kurukshetra University's Manisha, respectively, on their own.

Moreover, he noted that the Association of Indian Universities' (AIU) directive not to allow jobholders to participate was another major blow. And with the government announcing last year that all Khelo India medal winners, across all disciplines, will be eligible for government jobs, the admissible bracket for KIUG has been severely narrowed.

"These are the two main causes, because we have a limit of eight athletes qualifying for the competition. So if three or four of them go out because of these reasons, then we are obviously faced with a problem," Save noted.

However, despite the shortage of participants, the track and field events produced a fair share of memorable moments. A total of 12 meet records were set across the 45 events that took place in the men's and women's categories.

And perhaps the best was saved for last as India's fastest man, Animesh Kujur, lined up for Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology (KIIT) in the men's 4x100m final, much to the excitement of spectators and participants alike.

And, true to expectations, Animesh, along with D. Mrutyam Jayaram, Santa Mahendra and Abhay Singh, hurried to the finish line in meet record time (40.09s) to bring the curtain down on the athletics events at the Games. After the race, Animesh admitted that breaking the meet record was the only reason that motivated him to run, while also highlighting the importance of such university competitions, adding that "It is a very important platform for young athletes to be identified."

But with KIUG not acting as a qualification event for any next step, but rather as an extensive talent-hunt programme, the question remains as to whether it is — or ever can be — enticing enough to draw in the biggest athletes, who in turn could provide the rest of the field with tougher competition and the drive to do more.

Honour board



Chandigarh University:
42 gold, 14 silver, 11 bronze — 67

Lovely Professional University, (PB):
32, 24, 22 — 78

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar:
32, 22, 18 — 72

Jain University, Karnataka:
30, 9, 11 — 50

Guru Kashi University:
15, 15, 18 — 48

Panjab University Chandigarh:
14, 33, 19 — 66

Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology:
10, 3, 8 — 21

Savitribai Phule Pune University, MS:
9, 17, 12 — 38

Shivaji University:
4, 3, 13 — 20

Maharshi Dayanand University:
4, 2, 5 — 11